

The PHP Foundation & the Challenge of Sustaining Critical Digital Infrastructure

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The PHP
Foundation

Agenda

1 PHP as a volunteer-driven project

2 The PHP Foundation overview

3 Why sustaining open source is hard

4 Current funding efforts

5 Other funding models

6 How you can make a difference

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If PHP went away tomorrow,

**millions of individuals &
businesses**

would be directly impacted.



WooCommerce

**Volunteer-maintained,
under-funded,
under-resourced
but mission-critical
projects have risks.**

(No, really?)

1

Burnout

2

**Contributor Absence
Factor**

3

Slower development

4

**Keeping pace with
Security reports**

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**Enter The PHP Foundation:
Funding without language
governance**

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The PHP Foundation Mission:

Ensuring the long-term sustainability of PHP

1

Fund Development

Pay people to work on things like maintenance (bug triage, reviewing PRs, bug fixes, etc) and new features.

2

Grow the Community

Increase the number of users and contributors to the language.

3

Improve the Perception

Promote the PHP language as a viable and current solution for web and app development.

The PHP Foundation leadership:

1

Board of Directors

Sets Foundation strategy and funding priorities monthly, by consensus.

2

Advisory Board

Contributors, sponsors & ecosystem partners.
Feedback on major initiatives, not control.

3

Executive Director

That's me! Runs day-to-day operations, sets priorities with the Board, and serves as the Foundation's public voice.

In 2025:

2,929

commits across 9 PHP repositories

1,685

community PRs reviewed in php-src

42%

of all php-src commits

Engaging the PHP community for sustainability: Special Interest Groups

1

Ecosystem Security Team

Triage, disclosure, and tooling for under-resourced maintainers.

2

PHP Ambassador Program

Changing the perception of PHP to match the reality of modern day development

3

PHP Onboarding Initiative

Smoother setup and learning resources for newcomers.

4

Cryptography SIG

Post-quantum readiness across PHP core and the ecosystem.

5

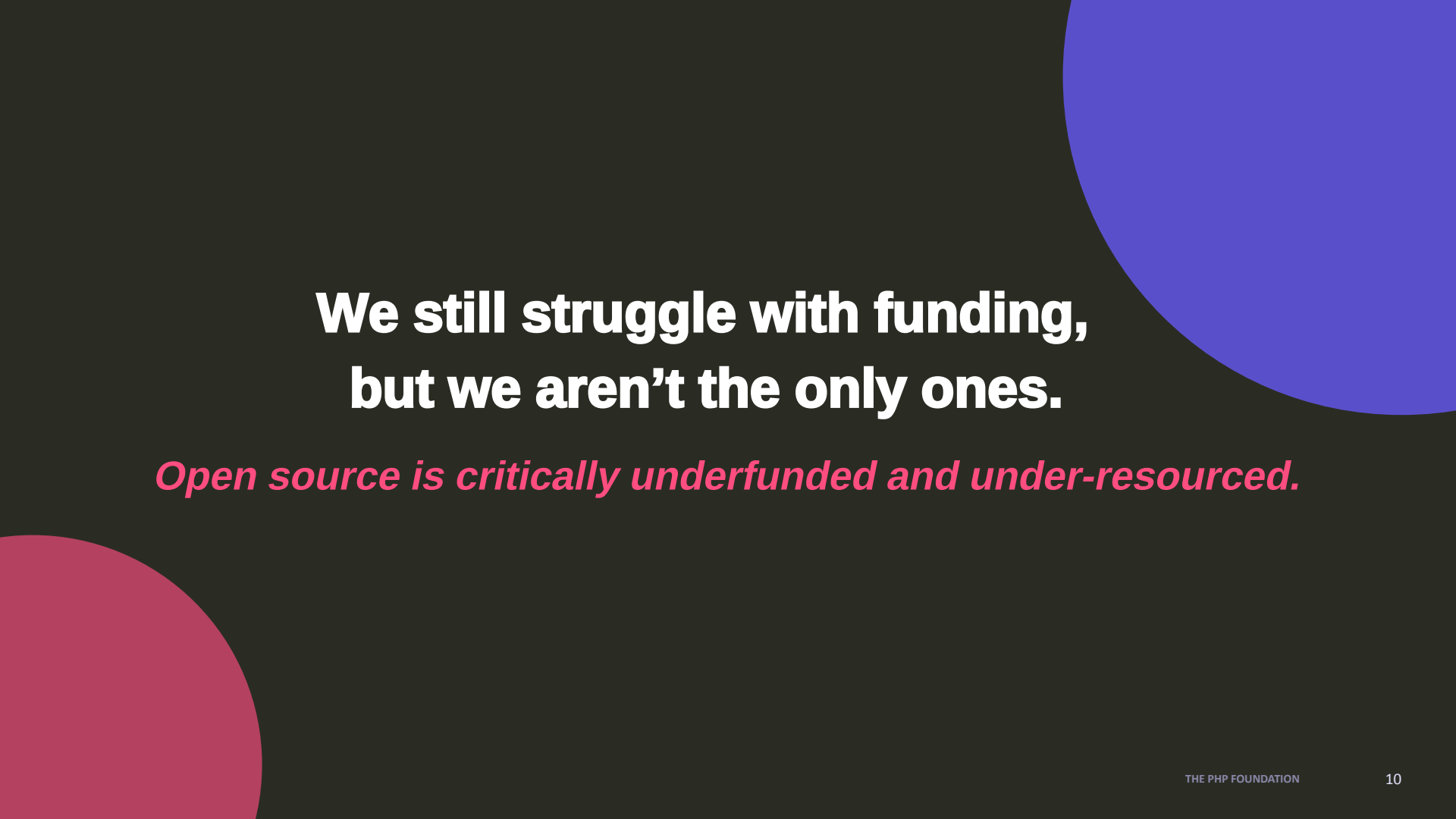
Community Events Coalition

Shared resources for user groups and conference organizers.

6

Accessibility & Inclusion

Making PHP, its docs, and its community more inclusive.



**We still struggle with funding,
but we aren't the only ones.**

Open source is critically underfunded and under-resourced.

Why sustaining open source is genuinely hard

1

Free rider problem

Anyone can use the software without paying for it, so most don't. There's no market pressure to fund something freely available to all.

2

Tragedy of the commons

Large entities not only fail to contribute, but they sometimes put an undue burden on small teams of maintainers, further depleting the resource.

3

“Free” is ambiguous

Free as in speech (freedom to use and modify) isn't free as in beer (zero cost), and conflating the two lets everyone assume someone else is paying.

And the incentives make it worse

1

Misaligned incentives

Companies build billion-dollar products on free dependencies, with no mechanism or budget line to pay back the value they capture.

2

Invisible dependency trees

Most organizations don't know what they depend on (or what those projects depend on) and you can't fund what you can't see.

3

Maintenance is thankless

Shipping v1.0 gets stars and conference talks. Patching a CVE in year eight gets nothing. Incentives reward creation, not upkeep.

How open source gets funded today

1

Donations & Sponsorship

GitHub Sponsors (\$100M+), the Open Source Pledge (>\$2K/dev/year), and thanks.dev, which auto-routes funds down your dependency tree.

2

Paid Support & Services

Dual-licensing, enterprise support contracts, Tidelift-style subscriptions.

3

Open Source Foundations & Endowments

Linux Foundation-style corporate backing, plus new models like the Open Source Endowment, which invests principal and grants only the returns.

4

Grants from Other Foundations and Governments

Germany's Sovereign Tech Agency (~€24.6M+) and Alpha-Omega/OpenSSF grants.

Other solutions on the table

1

The Great Refactor Fund

Jen Easterly's proposed \$1B public-interest fund, anchored by frontier AI labs and targeting dependency mapping, code hardening, and maintainer support by 2028.

2

Threshold-based funding

A Kickstarter-style Coasian model: “raise \$Y and we'll ship X.” All-or-nothing pledges ease free-rider fears, though skeptics may still withhold if they doubt the threshold will be hit.

3

Sustainable Usage Standards

Tiffany Farriss's proposal: treat maintenance as a billable operating cost, not charity, and standardizing operational costs in open source.

Even if the code is zero cost, the labor isn't.

58%

of maintainers have quit, or seriously
considered quitting, their projects

44%

cite burnout among their
top reasons for leaving

*Someone is answering that CVE at 2am. Someone is reviewing that RFC. That's
the real cost hiding behind “free and open source.”*

Be an advocate, wherever you are

1

Ask the question

“Do we pay for anything we depend on?” Most orgs never ask.

2

Push for a line item

Advocate for a real budget for open source sponsorship, not an afterthought.

3

Point people to the platforms

Open Collective, GitHub Sponsors, direct foundation sponsorship. Make it easy to say yes.

4

Advocate for non-cash support

Paid time to fix a bug, a sponsored conference talk, someone championing a project internally. Whatever that looks like inside your company.

Sustaining open source isn't a spectator activity.

*It is going to take all of us to make a change in
the way open source is resourced.*

Questions?

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Sources & references

THE PHP FOUNDATION

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- [Governance \(thephp.foundation\)](#)
- [Impact and Transparency Report 2025](#)
- [Announcing the Ecosystem Security Team](#)
- [PHP Foundation Founded \(The Register, 2021\)](#)
- [Foundation Strategy: Part 2 \(Community Feedback\)](#)
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FUNDING LANDSCAPE

- [\\$100 Million for Open Source \(GitHub Blog\)](#)
- [Sovereign Tech Agency \(sovereign.tech\)](#)
- [Alpha-Omega, a Linux Foundation Project](#)
- [Open Source Endowment \(endowment.dev\)](#)
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PERSPECTIVES & RESEARCH

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- [Herbie Bradley & Garish Sastry, "The Great Refactor"](#)
- [Tiffany Farriss, "Freedom Is Not Free," Palantir.net \(2026\)](#)
- [2023 Maintainer Survey \(Sonar, formerly Tidelift\)](#)